PRACTICE TRAINING

How requests are reviewed

Triage, small requests, and the idea log. How every request gets an answer, and how the roadmap stays focused on goals.

Where we are, and where we want to be

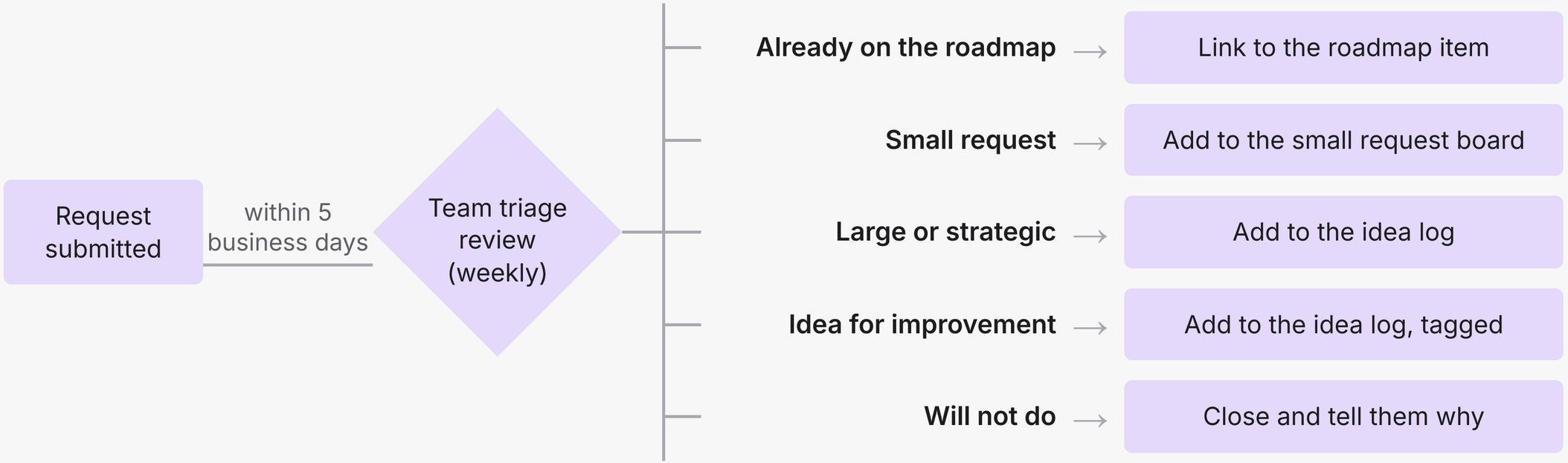
WHAT IT FEELS LIKE TODAY

- "I sent a request and never heard back."
- So the next ask comes as a hallway conversation, an email to a manager, or a call to someone who knows someone.
- The team gets pulled in every direction, and the loudest ask wins.
- Big ideas and small fixes sit in the same pile, and both wait.

WHERE WE WANT TO BE

- Every request gets an outcome within **5 business days**, and the requester is told.
- Small fixes get done, from a protected share of our time.
- Big ideas are kept, and looked at when we plan.
- The roadmap stays focused on goals.

How are my requests reviewed and categorized?



Every outcome ends the same way: the requester is told what happened.

Five outcomes, five tests

Already on the roadmap	The roadmap already covers it as an Initiative, Solution, or Deliverable.
Small request	A request to alter an existing functionality or item that can be completed in less than a single sprint.
Large or strategic	A request to either add new functionality or a request that will take longer than a single sprint.
Idea for improvement	A request to make the overall system better that would have impacts to people or groups beyond the requester.
Will not do	A request that cannot be accommodated for either feasibility, cost, or strategic reasons.

Improvement or small? Ideas for improvement stay separate because at triage we don't know their size. If it's a clear, bounded fix to something that exists, call it a small request even if others benefit.

Who is in the room

A 30 to 45 minute weekly meeting. Every request since the last review gets an outcome.

Product owner

Runs the review. Owns the small request board and steps in when its order needs to change. Sends or delegates each reply.

Product manager

Owns the idea log. Calls "already on the roadmap" and "will not do" for strategy reasons. Mines the log for patterns.

Content strategist

Brings requests from editors and partners, explains the context, and argues for the ones that matter most to them.

Technical architect or developer

Flags anything that may be infeasible or bigger than it looks.

Requesters

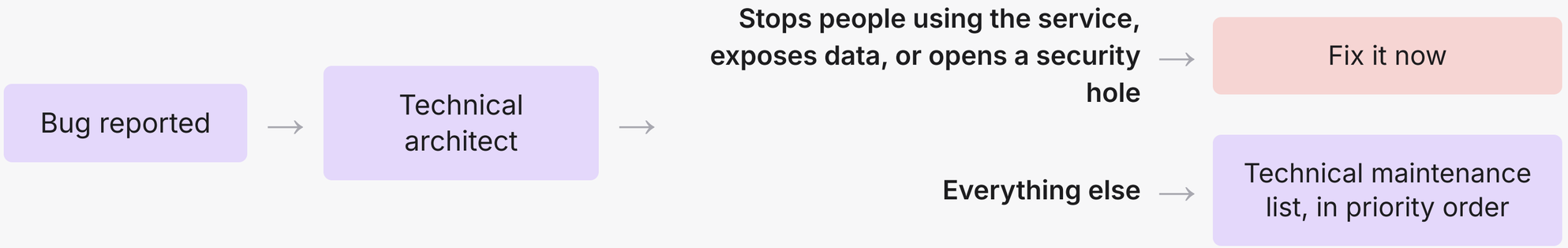
Don't attend. They get a reply.

Not here: scoring

No weighted models or 2×2s at triage. Those help compare large candidates at quarterly planning.

Bugs skip triage

A bug is something we built that doesn't work as intended. Nobody is asking for a change.



It counts as Technical maintenance

Bugs are paid for from Technical maintenance time, not small request time, whoever reported them.

Unless it isn't a bug

If a "bug" is really a request for different behavior, send it back to triage.

Every request gets an answer

Set expectations, and explain any no and why.

Already on the roadmap	"This is already part of [roadmap item]. You can follow progress here."
Small request	"This is on our small request board. We work these in the order they arrive, unless something is urgent, and expect to get to it within [typical time]. We'll tell you when it's done."
Large or strategic	"This is bigger than a quick fix, so we've added it to our idea log. We review the log every quarter when we plan. We can't promise a date."
Idea for improvement	"This could help more people than the original ask, so we've logged it as an improvement idea. We'll look at it more closely when we plan next quarter."
Will not do	"We won't be taking this on because [reason]." Plus an alternative, if there is one.

A no with a reason builds more trust than silence. If nobody hears back, the next request goes around the system as a hallway ask.

Future consideration: not yes, not no

Some ideas are worth keeping but don't fit our strategy or capacity now, and nothing tells us when they will. After the product manager reviews an idea, this status tells the requester three things plainly:

We aren't saying yes	We aren't saying no	We won't get back to you

The idea stays in the log. If it fits a future quarter, the product manager will find it there. The requester can always ask again, especially if something changes on their side.

WHY IT EXISTS

The alternative is silence. People read silence as a forgotten yes or a quiet no, so they keep waiting or keep asking.

Saying "we won't follow up" once is kinder than leaving them to guess.

Large requests get a conversation

Most arrive as a solution with a deadline attached: "we need a portal by July."

1. **Is the problem clear, rather than a solution?**
   Ask what happens today, who it affects, and what goes wrong. If nobody can say, the first step is discovery.

2. **Is there a hard deadline?**
   Separate a mandate (law, policy, funding) from a wish. A real mandate makes it Required work, which still competes at planning.

3. **Do we need more discovery?**
   If the problem is real but unclear, it becomes a discovery candidate for planning.

4. **Can the scope be reduced?**
   Sometimes a smaller version solves most of the problem and fits as a small request now.

5. **Does the partner understand how we work?**
   Explain the quarterly cycle: what can happen now, what waits for planning, and when they will hear.

The partner leaves knowing what happens next and when they will hear. The outcome: a planning candidate, Required work, a small request, Future consideration, or will not do.

Example: a portal for oversize load permits by July

DMV Motor Carrier unit. The product manager met the unit lead with the UX designer and researcher.

1. Problem	Carriers fax applications, and a third come back for missing route details. The problem is rework, not the lack of a portal.
2. Deadline	July is the start of construction season. A wish, not a mandate.
3. Discovery	Needed. Nobody knows which route details go missing or why.
4. Reduced scope	A fillable route checklist on the existing permits page fits as a small request now.
5. How we work	The lead heard that a portal would be considered at Q3 planning at the earliest.

Small request board

The fillable route checklist.

Idea log

"Carriers resubmit oversize permits," as a discovery candidate for Q3 planning.

How does small request work get prioritized and scheduled?

Ready	In sprint	Done	Requester told
first in, first out	pulled this sprint		
Route checklist on the permits page	Sticker arrival date on the renewal confirmation	Address change link on the renewal start page	New study guide link on the test page
Title transfer fee table			
Holiday hours banner			

A capacity share, not roadmap work

Small requests get a fixed share of team time, 25% by default, set each quarter. "It's not a road mapping activity."

First in, first out

Requests are pulled in the order they arrived. Urgency can move one up, and the product owner can step in to reorder.

Patterns go up, requests stay put

When several small requests point to the same problem, add that pattern to the idea log.

How does the team balance its work?

Product manager	Product owner	Technical architect
orders	orders	orders
Strategic Roadmap Initiatives and Deliverables	**Small requests** From triage, first in, first out	**Technical maintenance** Including bugs, in priority order
50% of team time	**25% of team time**	**25% of team time**

Triage feeds two of the three. Small requests go to the product owner's board. Large and strategic ideas go to the product manager's idea log, which feeds the roadmap at planning. The split is set each quarter.

The idea log is a toy chest, not a queue

Logging promises one thing

That the idea won't get lost. No commitment, no date, no place in line.

The product manager mines it

At quarterly planning, for candidates to frame as Initiatives. At direction setting, for patterns that might shape strategy.

Most ideas never become Initiatives

And that is expected. Each one moves from Needs review to Mined into an Initiative, Future consideration, or Closed.

Triage is where requests come in. **Planning is where the ideas get used.**

Log ideas freely and promise nothing. Nobody should read "logged" as "scheduled."

Try it: a DMV triage review

Tuesday, January 21. Give each request one of the five outcomes.

"Can people renew their registration online yet?"	Field office manager	?
"The renewal confirmation page doesn't say when the sticker arrives."	Call center lead	?
"Let people book a knowledge test appointment online."	Public comment	?
"Show a document checklist before someone comes in for a new license."	Counter clerk	?
"Turn the paper renewal form into a fillable PDF."	Records unit	?

Outcomes: Already on the roadmap, Small request, Large or strategic, Idea for improvement, Will not do.

How the team called it

Tuesday, January 21.

"Can people renew their registration online yet?"	Field office manager	**Already on the roadmap: linked to the Vehicle Renewal Service**
"The renewal confirmation page doesn't say when the sticker arrives."	Call center lead	**Small request: added to the board**
"Let people book a knowledge test appointment online."	Public comment	**Large or strategic: idea log**
"Show a document checklist before someone comes in for a new license."	Counter clerk	**Idea for improvement: idea log, tagged to Goal 2**
"Turn the paper renewal form into a fillable PDF."	Records unit	**Will not do: we will not digitize existing broken processes**

The no came with a reason and a path: "Our strategy is to redesign renewal end to end rather than put the old form online, and the online renewal service is already in progress. Here is where to follow it."

Rules of thumb

Every request gets an answer.

A no with a reason builds more trust than silence. So does "not now, and we won't follow up."

Meet the requester before a large request goes in the log.

Most arrive as solutions. The problem underneath is usually smaller or different.

Small requests belong to the product owner.

If the product manager is ordering the board, the bucket has turned into a second roadmap.

Don't score requests at triage.

Scoring models and 2×2s belong at planning, not in a 45-minute weekly meeting.

Roadmap goals are about the people the service exists for.

Editors and staff matter, and most of their asks are small fixes.

Patterns go up, requests stay put.

Twelve requests about the same problem make one idea. The twelve stay small requests.